righteous behaviour laid down by the Zoroastrian religion. Nothing, perhaps, testified to his unwavering commitment to these values more than the liquidation process of his cotton trading firm after it folded up in a financial crisis. Jamsetji presented his case so ‘frankly’ that his creditors and the banks, impressed with his ‘honesty’, ‘appointed him his own liquidator, with an allowance of £20 a month’.

‘Salvation’ is not just achieved by doing good but is also predicated ‘upon the good deeds of those whom he left behind’ and all the Parsis working to ‘apply themselves to the building up of society in righteousness’. These principles have their origin in ‘Zoroaster’s mission upon earth’, which was to ‘guide man to the choice of right’. JRD wanted to choose as his successor one who was sworn to ethical conduct and righteousness. He did not do so for religious reasons, but for the fact that these ethical principles of Zoroastrianism had become the group’s touchstones. Among all the contenders, Ratan followed these edicts the most.

JRD acknowledged this attribute, saying: ‘It would be an advantage to continue with the Tata name, and I believe Ratan Tata has the abilities and the spirit to maintain the philosophy of the group.’

After Ratan’s appointment, *Asiaweek* wrote that ‘J.R.D. must have seen something of himself—bedrock values and integrity’ in Ratan. J.J. Irani, who was handpicked by JRD to join Tata Steel and was its MD from 1992 to 2001, recalled that JRD had virtually no worldly possessions that he could call his own, and had no desire for them. He never accepted any gifts from anyone. Even the car he drove belonged to the Tata Trusts. His residence in Bombay, The Cairn, was rented from the Avabai F. Petit Residuary Estate Trust.

The younger Tata’s commitment to these values, if anything, is even more fastidious, cemented as it was in his impressionable years by Lady Tata, whose ‘unbending ethical framework’ was the foundation of her life. And this might have influenced JRD’s decision in favour of the younger Tata. But he downplayed Ratan’s strong ethical values as a distinguishing factor so as not to sound less complimentary about the other candidates. When asked if Ratan stood apart on this score, he said, ‘Oh, no, you can’t say that! It would imply that the other contenders did not have integrity.’ While speaking to R.M. Lala ten days after Ratan was appointed chairman, JRD revealed his inner mind, saying that Ratan had ‘integrity of my type’.